



Why every PMO needs a strategy, not just a process

Many PMOs drift into reporting and firefighting. This article shows how the PMO Operating Model Wheel, a maturity model and continuous improvement help a PMO deliver predictable, value-driven results.

A PMO without structure tends to become reactive. It spends its time collecting reports and chasing updates instead of helping projects succeed. A modern PMO does something different: it acts as a strategic partner that enables predictable, value-driven delivery.

Why PMOs struggle

The same patterns appear again and again:

- no clear governance
- inconsistent delivery
- low stakeholder confidence
- a “supplier versus client” mindset
- a breakdown in culture

Each one makes the PMO harder to trust, and a PMO that isn't trusted is rarely asked to influence decisions.

A model for the whole PMO

The PMO Operating Model Wheel gives a PMO four connected domains, all centred on predictable, value-driven delivery:

- **Governance & Assurance:** confidence, consistency and control.
- **Planning & Control:** structure, visibility and predictability.
- **People, Skills & Culture:** capability, collaboration and leadership.
- **Value, Strategy & Outcomes:** alignment, measurement and improvement.

Weakness in one domain undermines the others, so the domains need to be developed together.

Knowing where you stand

The maturity model describes five levels:

1. **Reactive:** firefighting, no governance.

2. **Structured:** governance begins to take shape.
3. **Proactive:** the PMO enables delivery rather than just observing it.
4. **Strategic:** the PMO influences decisions.
5. **Enterprise:** the PMO drives organisational change.

Rating each Wheel domain against these levels, with evidence, shows where to focus first.

Improving continuously

A PMO that doesn't evolve becomes irrelevant. The continuous improvement cycle (Assess, Improve, Measure, Embed) turns one-off fixes into daily practice. Embedding is the step most often skipped.

A turnaround in practice

In one documented case, a PMO was failing its SLAs and KPIs, with revenue down 10%. A delivery model reset, a governance redesign and cultural change led to a 30% improvement in delivery. Customer satisfaction rose from 3 to 7, revenue moved from -10% to +15%, SLA achievement reached 100%, and most projects moved from red to green.

Where to start

1. Assess your PMO's maturity in each of the four domains.
2. Pick one domain to strengthen first, usually governance.
3. Set measures such as CSAT, SLA compliance and ROI, then review them regularly.

To work through these tools step by step, take the free course [Leading and Maturing a Modern PMO](#).

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